# Mother Russia

Arriving in Moscow, Honecker faced a city bigger, but significantly less elegant, than some he had passed through on the journey. But that didn't matter, the young communist had found his utopia – the epicentre of a country undergoing colossal upheaval, where workers and peasants were creating a socialist paradise as Stalin's 'Piatiletka' – or 'Five-Year Plans' thrusting the country into modernity.

As his train clattered into the Byelorussia station, he caught a glimpse of a huge sign above the platform displaying the words: 'Workers of all countries unite' – a moment of overwhelming excitement. With his political views already settled, he would spend the next year diligently confirming them at the International Lenin School, a Georgian-looking establishment located off the famous Arbat at 25 Vorovskogo Street – an upscale area, nowadays referred to as Ambassadors' Row.1

The school was founded in the mid-1920s by the Comintern – a Soviet-controlled organisation that governed communist parties around the globe. In practical terms, the Soviets directed enormous resources to 'educating' foreign students and, as sponsors, picked up the tab for operating such establishments. Using the cover name 'Fritz Malter' (all students and teachers used pseudonyms), Honecker was surrounded by the most promising young communists from Europe, America, Africa and Asia. He shared a room with Anton Ackermann – who would later become a close collaborator in the East German government. Fred Oelsner, who after 1945 would also shine in the GDR administration, was a lecturer at the school. Teaching methods combined lectures, study and discussions, and for the entrance examination he wrote an essay on the global economic crisis, which, he said, was well received and 'the way was opened for me to study Marxism-Leninism'. From then on, long hours were spent in the library brushing up on his Russian language skills, which he never perfected. He devoured (and memorised) the ABC of Communism – a tome penned by